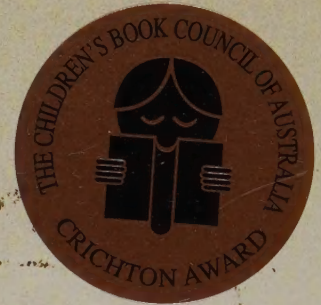


# BIG RED KANGAROO



CLAIRE SAXBY & GRAHAM BYRNE





This  
Nature Storybook

belongs to:

.....

.....













# BIG RED

With love, to Kerry. CS

To Possum, for support and  
warm fur, and to Gordon, for the  
big question and courage. GB

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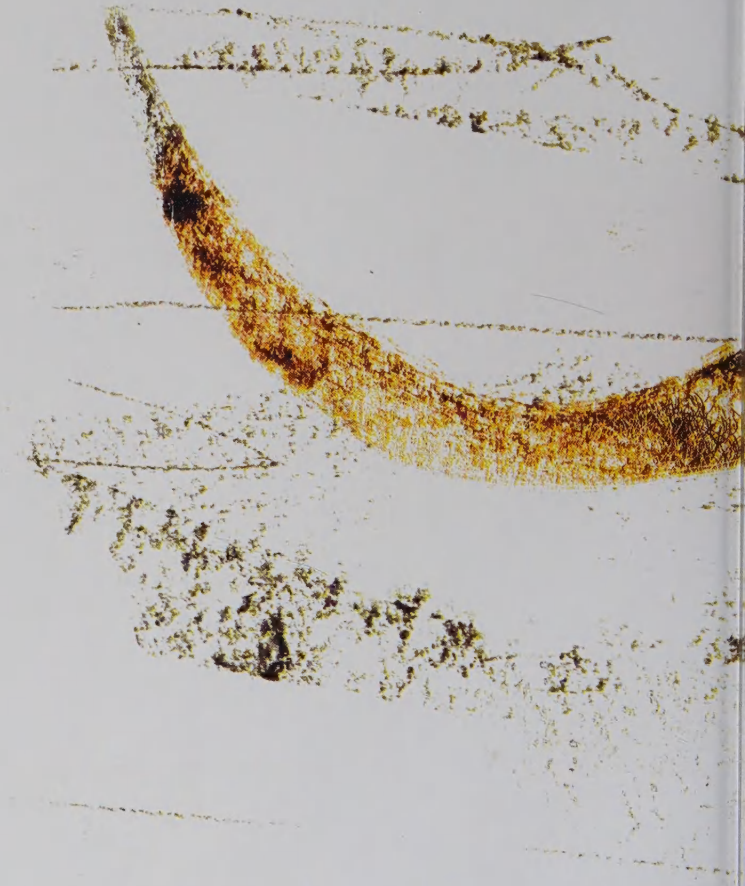
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# KANGAROO



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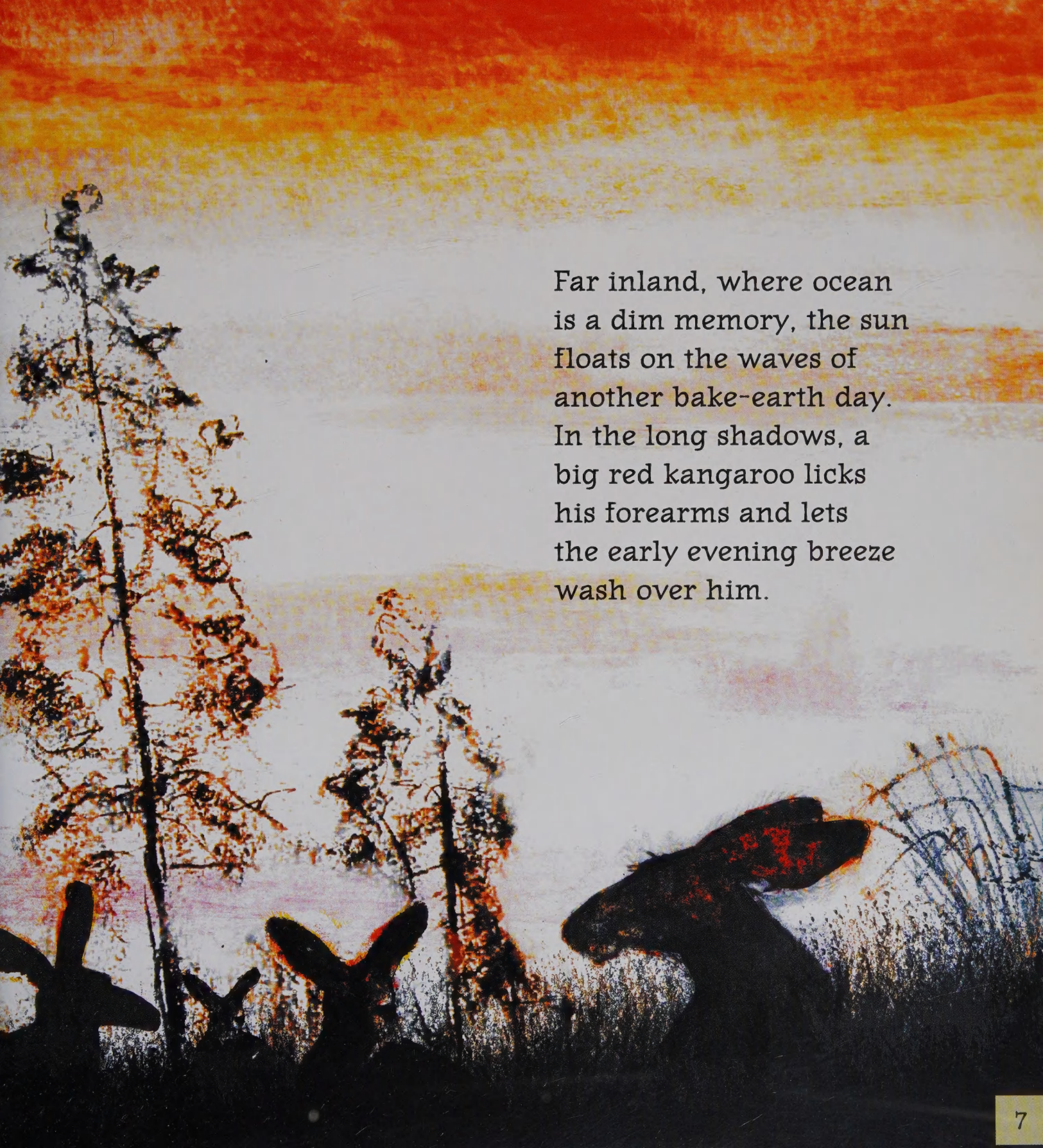
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Far inland, where ocean  
is a dim memory, the sun  
floats on the waves of  
another bake-earth day.  
In the long shadows, a  
big red kangaroo licks  
his forearms and lets  
the early evening breeze  
wash over him.



This is Red.

He appears relaxed, almost lazy, but if you watch closely, you'll see his ears twitch. He is alert.

Around him, females, joeys and young kangaroos also stir. This is his mob.





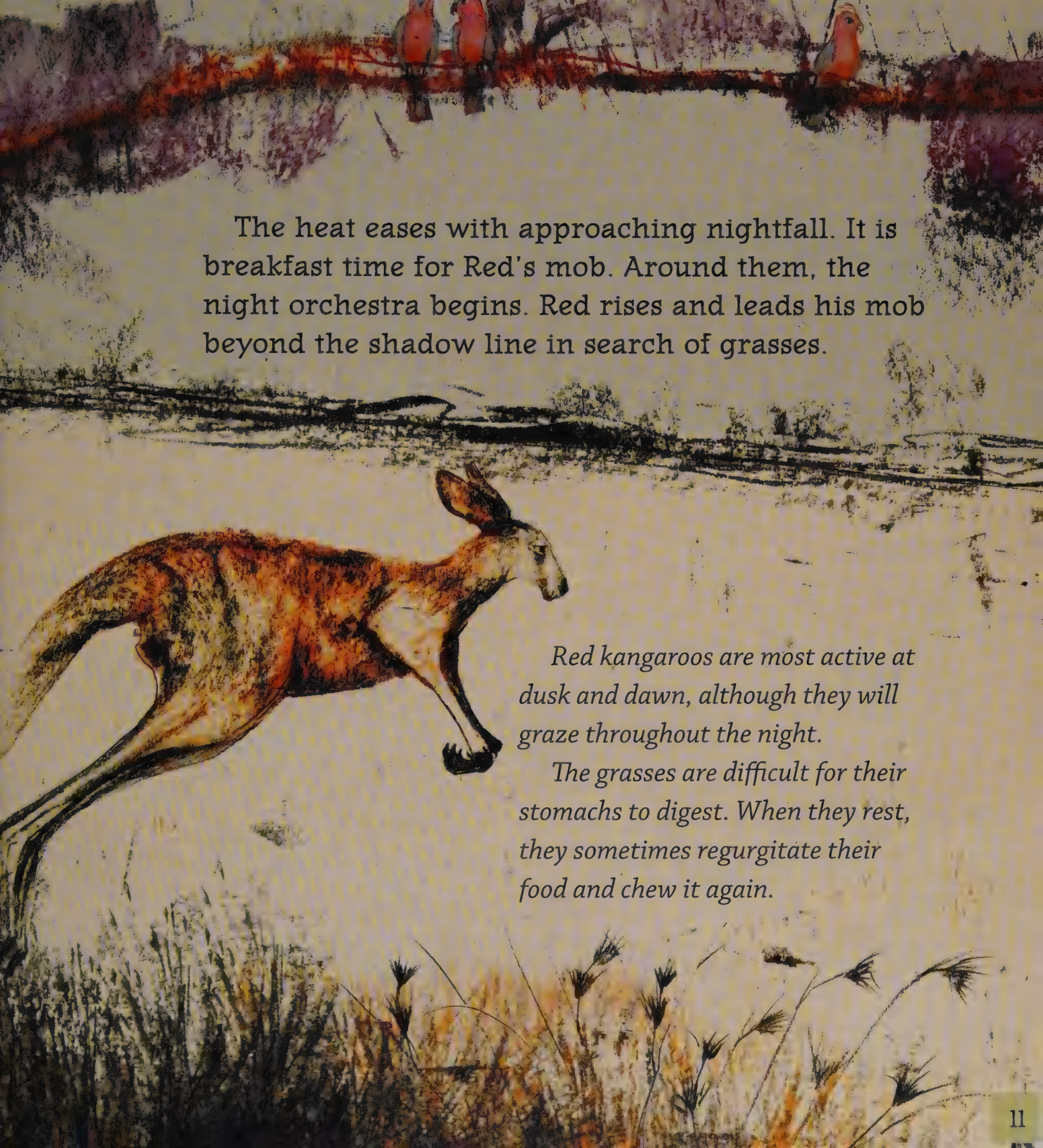
*Red kangaroos live in families called mobs. The groups usually contain a dominant male, at least one female and several joeys (baby kangaroos). Like all families, group size varies.*









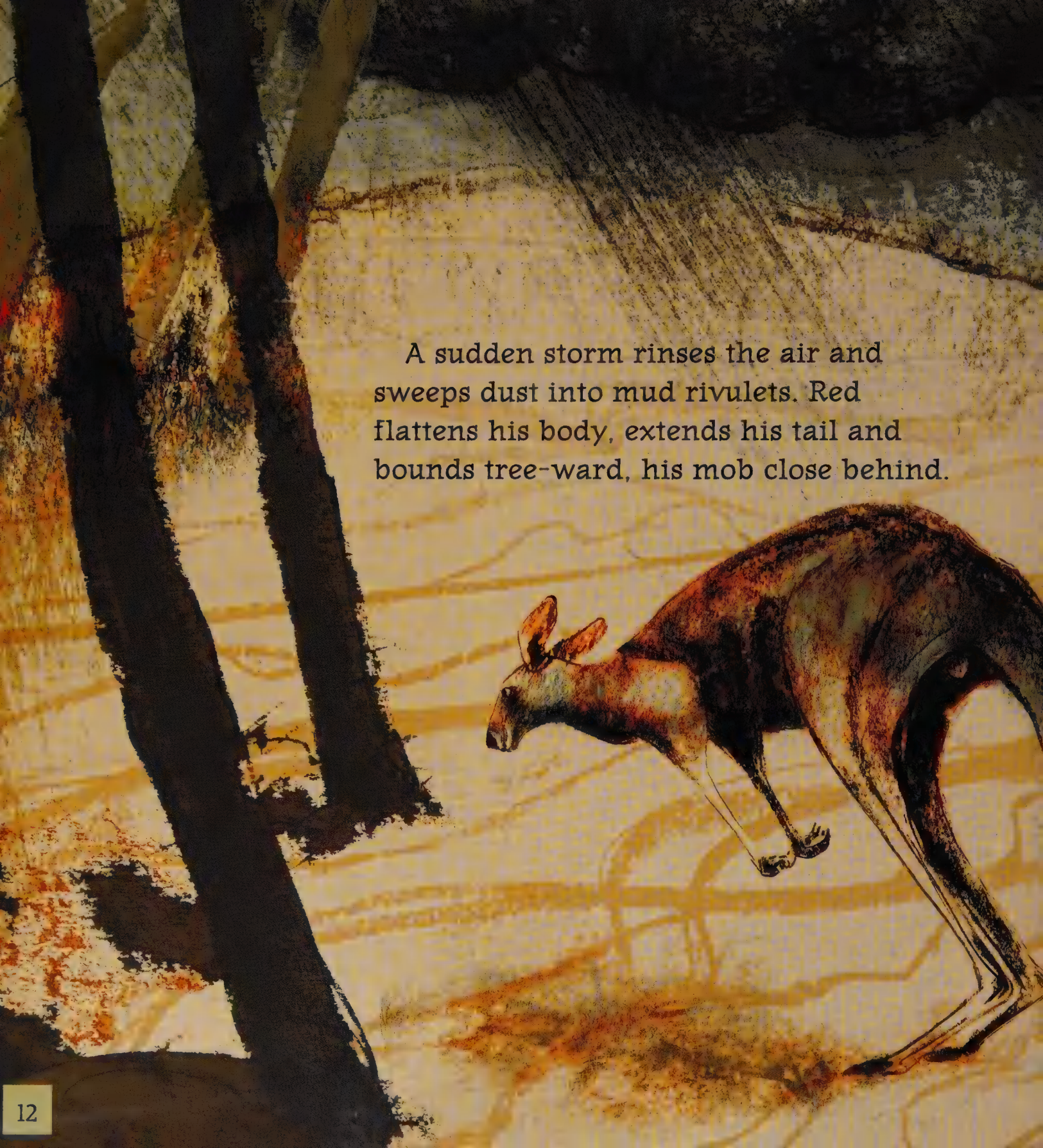


The heat eases with approaching nightfall. It is breakfast time for Red's mob. Around them, the night orchestra begins. Red rises and leads his mob beyond the shadow line in search of grasses.

*Red kangaroos are most active at dusk and dawn, although they will graze throughout the night.*

*The grasses are difficult for their stomachs to digest. When they rest, they sometimes regurgitate their food and chew it again.*



A watercolor illustration of a deer running towards a tree. The deer is in the lower right, facing left, with its body flattened and tail extended. The background is a mix of dark, textured brushstrokes and lighter, yellowish washes. A large, dark tree trunk is on the left side of the frame.

A sudden storm rinses the air and  
sweeps dust into mud rivulets. Red  
flattens his body, extends his tail and  
bounds tree-ward, his mob close behind.





*A kangaroo's tail is long and strong. It works almost as another leg when slow-hopping or standing still. When a kangaroo moves at full speed, its tail acts like a rudder and helps with balance.*





Other groups of kangaroos join them in the shelter of the trees. Red watches.

A young male wanders too close to Red's mob. Red stands proud, shoulders back. It is a warning. The young kangaroo hops away. He is no threat today.







*Each mob has a single strong male as leader. If he shows signs of weakness, other males will challenge his position to become the head of the mob.*

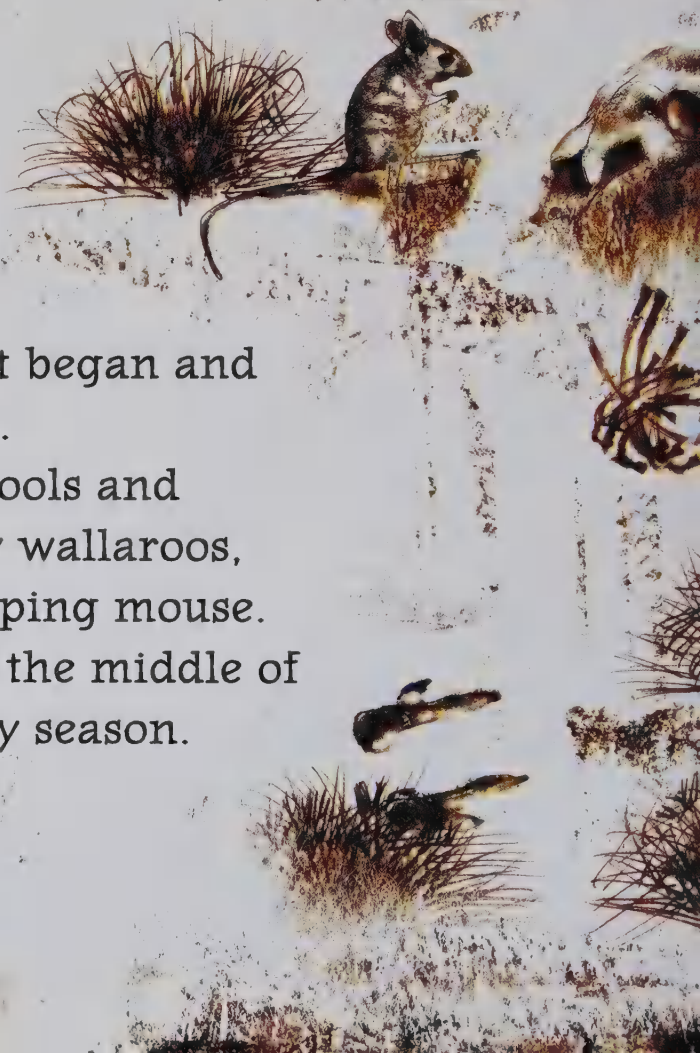
*A full-grown male red kangaroo can weigh as much as ninety kilograms and may reach 1.8 metres in height when standing.*





The rain ends as suddenly as it began and the kangaroos venture out again.

Rainwater loiters in shallow pools and Red drinks. The mob is joined by wallaroos, thorny devils and a spinifex hopping mouse. There is not much water here in the middle of the land, in the middle of the dry season.







*Kangaroos get most of their water from the plants they eat, but they will drink from puddles and streams if they can. When the season is good and food is plentiful, they may not drink much water at all.*



Red cannot settle while other males are so close. It is time to move. He sets off east, his mob close behind. His hops are long. Each landing pushes air from his lungs, each bound fills them.







*When red kangaroos want to travel faster, they make each hop longer, rather than take more hops. This conserves their energy so they can travel long distances.*





Red halts at a broad, shallow plain that sits lower than the surrounding land. This depression caught a shower last week and now blushes green in the moonlight. Red sniffs the air, listens, then settles to eat. Tuft by green tuft, he chews and swallows.

The night is alive with stars. Animals too. Most Red can ignore. Only dingo is dangerous, with his stealth and sharp teeth.



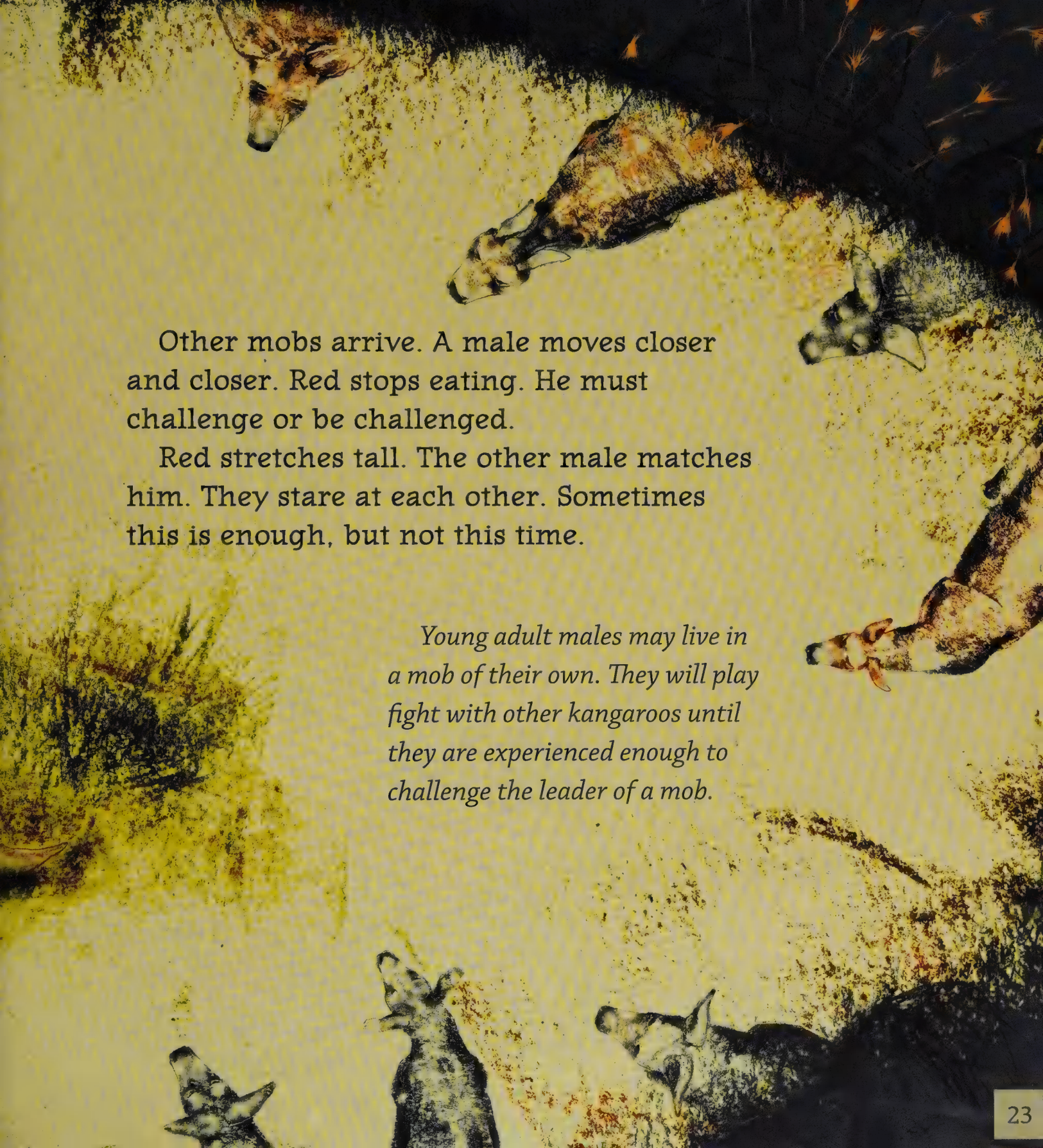


*Red kangaroos have few natural predators. Large goannas sometimes take young joeys in the daytime. When the earth cools, goannas move more slowly and it is night-hunting dingoes that are more dangerous.*







A detailed illustration of a kangaroo mob in a dry, yellowish-brown landscape. Several kangaroos are visible: one at the top left looking down, a large one in the upper center looking left, a smaller one to its right looking left, and another on the right side looking left. In the bottom left, two more kangaroos are shown from the back, looking towards the center. The background features sparse, dry vegetation and a few small orange flowers. The overall style is that of a children's book illustration.

Other mobs arrive. A male moves closer and closer. Red stops eating. He must challenge or be challenged.

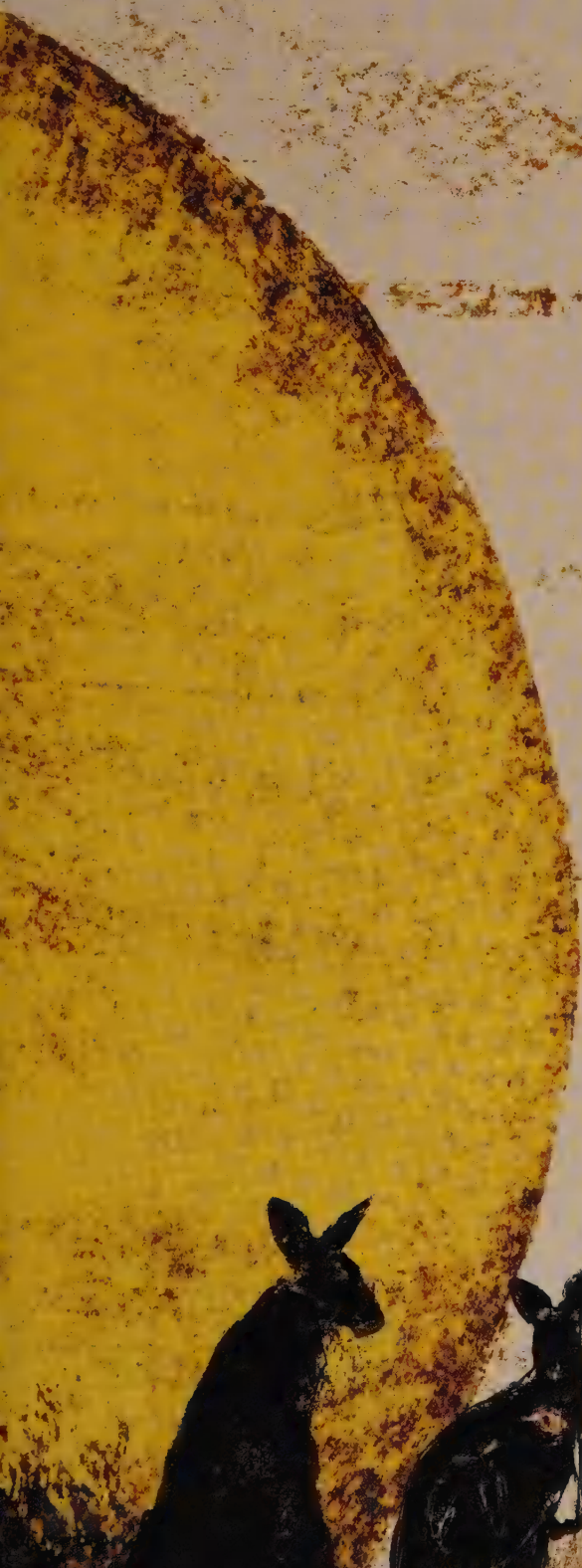
Red stretches tall. The other male matches him. They stare at each other. Sometimes this is enough, but not this time.

*Young adult males may live in a mob of their own. They will play fight with other kangaroos until they are experienced enough to challenge the leader of a mob.*









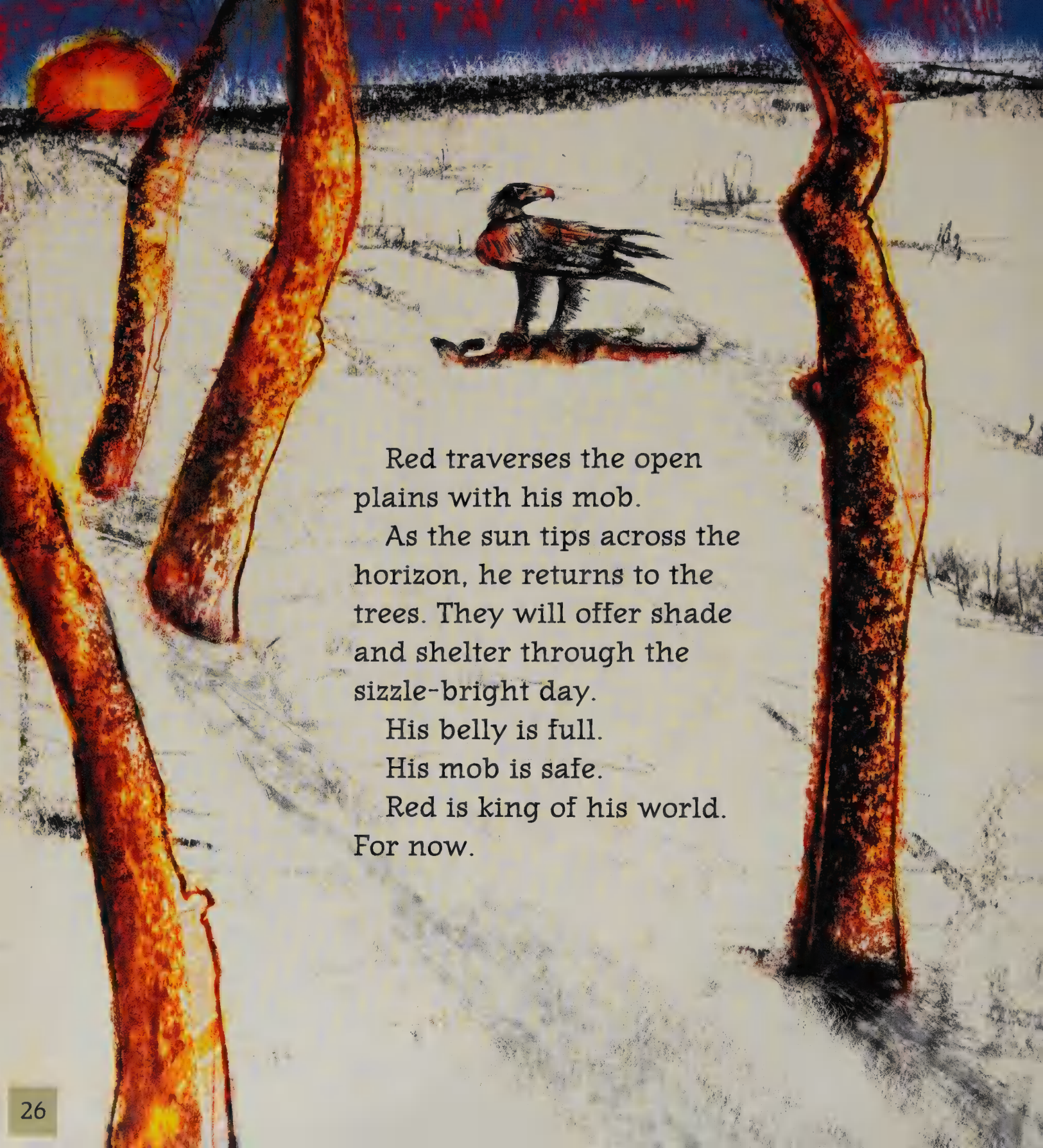
Red pushes up on his toes, braces against his tail. He tips his head back and lashes out, first one paw then the other. The other male strikes too, but wildly. Red's next hit will end it.

The challenger retreats, all fight gone from him.

*Fights for dominance can be fierce but are usually brief. The loser will withdraw before either kangaroo is really hurt.*







Red traverses the open  
plains with his mob.

As the sun tips across the  
horizon, he returns to the  
trees. They will offer shade  
and shelter through the  
sizzle-bright day.

His belly is full.

His mob is safe.

Red is king of his world.  
For now.



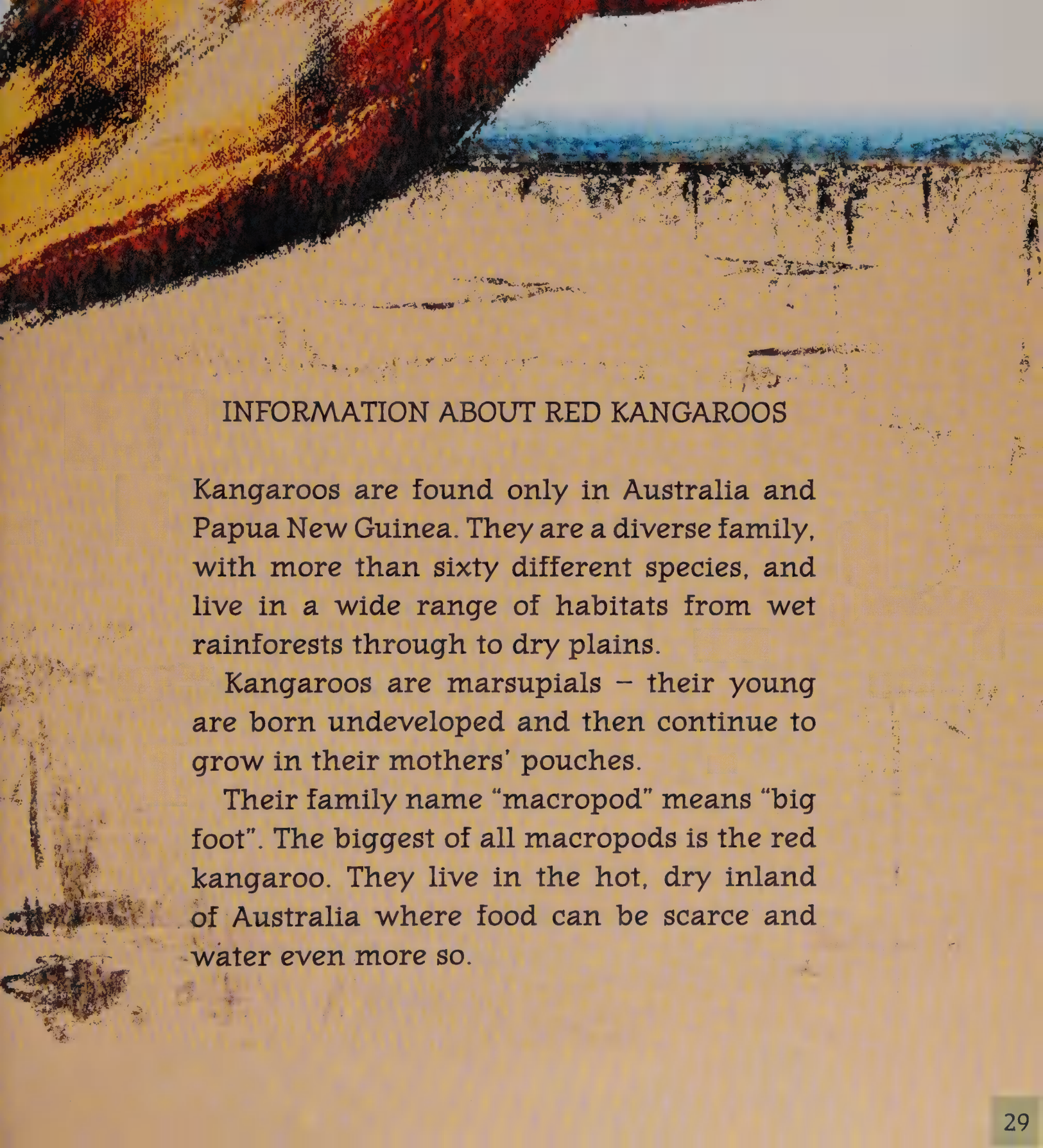


*When a male kangaroo is no longer the biggest or strongest, his mob will follow a new leader. This gives the mob the best chance of survival in a harsh environment.*









## INFORMATION ABOUT RED KANGAROOS

Kangaroos are found only in Australia and Papua New Guinea. They are a diverse family, with more than sixty different species, and live in a wide range of habitats from wet rainforests through to dry plains.

Kangaroos are marsupials – their young are born undeveloped and then continue to grow in their mothers' pouches.

Their family name “macropod” means “big foot”. The biggest of all macropods is the red kangaroo. They live in the hot, dry inland of Australia where food can be scarce and water even more so.



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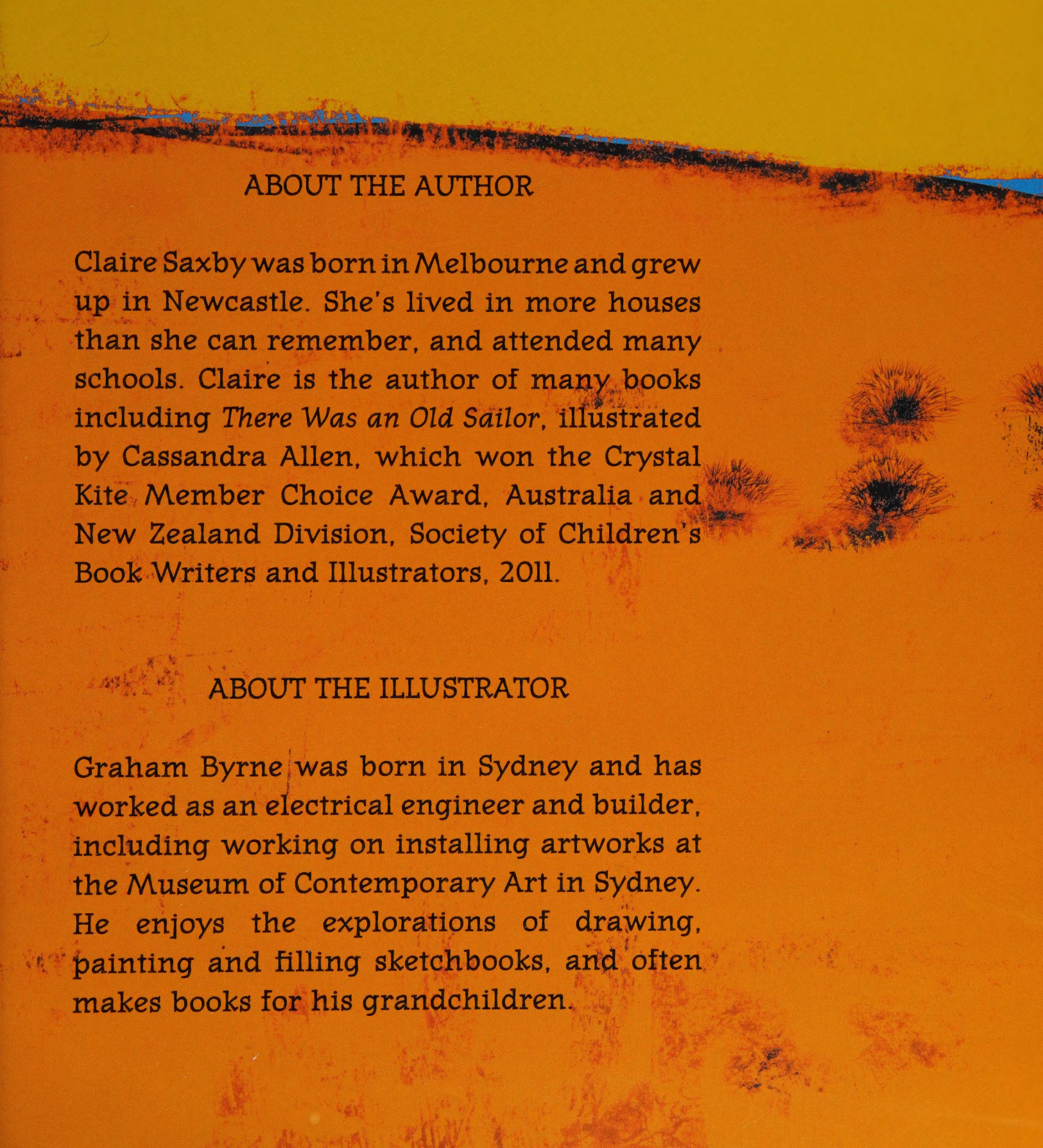
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Look up the pages to find out all about kangaroo things.

Don't forget to look at both kinds of word —

this kind and *this kind*





## ABOUT THE AUTHOR

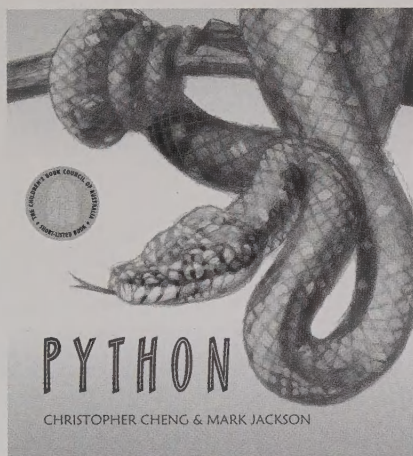
Claire Saxby was born in Melbourne and grew up in Newcastle. She's lived in more houses than she can remember, and attended many schools. Claire is the author of many books including *There Was an Old Sailor*, illustrated by Cassandra Allen, which won the Crystal Kite Member Choice Award, Australia and New Zealand Division, Society of Children's Book Writers and Illustrators, 2011.

## ABOUT THE ILLUSTRATOR

Graham Byrne was born in Sydney and has worked as an electrical engineer and builder, including working on installing artworks at the Museum of Contemporary Art in Sydney. He enjoys the explorations of drawing, painting and filling sketchbooks, and often makes books for his grandchildren.



# Nature Storybooks



## PYTHON

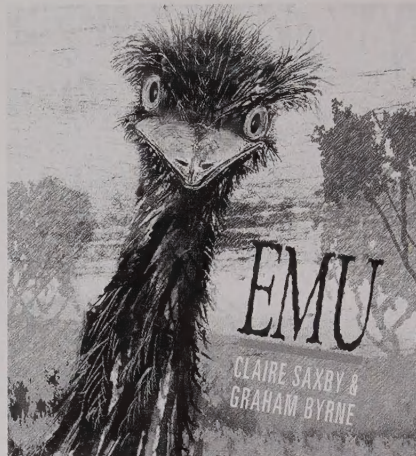
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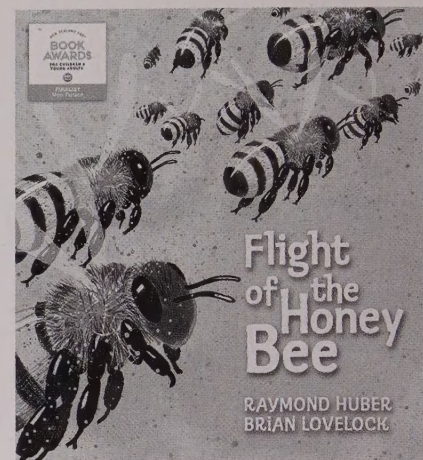
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# Nature Storybooks

Every wonderful word is true!



Far inland, the sun floats  
on the waves of a bake-earth day.  
Big Red and his mob of kangaroos  
wait for night-time  
when they can search for food.  
Young male kangaroos wait too —  
ready to challenge Red  
and take his place as leader.

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